

NOTES ON GST 113- NIGERIA'S PEOPLES AND CULTURE JUNE,2022

Nigeria provides a good example of a deeply divided society. In terms of ethnic composition, Nigeria has been estimated to inhabit over 350 ethnic nationalities with a population of 204.5 m people according World meter Elaboration of the latest UN Data, July 2021. These groups are not only distinguished by Languages, customs, and myths of origin but vary in Size, power and influence., thus making Nigeria a classic example of a state with unequal relations.(Agaba, 2006:506) In 1914, the Northern and Southern protectorates were fused together or amalgamated by the then Governor General Lord Lugard. Since then, Nigeria hasfaced myriad of problems because of its ethnic diversity. The most salient issues have been;

- i) How to cope with problems of multiethnic society
- ii) Problems emanating from threats of succession
- iii) How to accommodate the differences among the ethnic groups in the true spirit of unity in diversity.

Arising from these gamut's of problems, several ethnic nationalities have raised questions on issues that border on political and economic exclusion and marginalization. Besides, the Nigeria state has experienced the worst economic crisis in recent years especially high unemployment, slow economic growth, amidst devalued currency, and rising cost of living. At the moment, half of the population is multi- dimensionally poor. On the other hand, the country has been bedeviled by one security challenge or the other. As an instance, there is banditry in the north West, Islamic extremism in the north East, farmer- herder contestations in the north central, Separatist violence in the south -East, gangs and cult violence in the south -West, militancy and piracy in the south- south.

The federal government of Nigeria responded to these myriads of problems that engulf the various nationalities through section 14 of the constitutional provision. This was expected to guarantee fairness, equity and justice in the society. The provision also involves power sharing, regulates competition and access to resources as a means of protecting groups considered to be relatively disadvantaged to enable such groups have a sense of belonging in the federal system.In spite of all attempts to address this potpourri of issues that affect different ethnic groups in Nigeria, new problems emanate from this arrangement. There are issues that stem from this challenge such as;

- i)How to manage the diversities
- ii)Give each group access to power, political and economic privileges

Section 25, the constitution categorizes how an individual can become a citizen in order to protect the right of all groups. This can be by i) Birthii) Registration iii) Marriage

- iv) Naturalization. However, in an attempt to protect disadvantaged groups through the federal Character principle, salient problems emanate from this arrangement, such as the problem of **Indigene/Settler Dichotomy**.

This has become more problematic than what it purports to protect. we must note that the indigeneity question is an infringement on the right of other Nigerians. This can be understood against the backdrop that ethnic nationalities from varying backgrounds are denied their fundamental rights where they live. This results in conflictual relations. Media commentators have identified primal factors in these persistent intergroup relations;

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| i)Indigene/settler dichotomy | v) non-implementation of finding |
| ii)land contestations | vi) Ethno-religious conflicts |
| iii) Feeling of exclusion | vii) farmer-herder contestation |
| iv)resource control | viii) Ecological conflict |

Ecological conflicts are quite recent in north central Nigeria. Ecological conflicts occur where ecological dynamics interface with climate change tobring land users into conflictive relations. In Contemporary times, ecological conflicts have become a

reoccurring decimal in the geo-political region. It often results to loss of lives and destruction of economic investments and population displacement. A larger part of

ecological conflicts occur in north central Nigeria.This can be explained against the

background that these groups have different images of their histories, cultural identities, a

sense of originality, and indigeneity question because some of the groups are viewed as settlers within the context of the land they occupy.We can x-ray some of these conflicts in each geo-political zone;

NORTH -CENTRAL NIGERIA

1.Tiv vs Jukun

2.Alago vs Eggon (Assakio)

3.Tiv vs Azara (Aljenu crisis)

4.Mighili vs Eggon (Agyaragu

5. Bassa vs Ebira (Umaisha Toto LGA.

6. Berom, Anaguta, Afizere vs Hausa Community in Jos North LGA

7.Nri vs Nwagavul (Mangu and Bokkos LGA

8.Eggon Revolts at Alakyo

SOUTH -WEST NIGERIA

- 1.Ife vs Modakeke
2. Odua Peoples Congress vs Hausa (Shagamu Lagos

SOUTH-EAST NIGERIA

- 1.Aguleri vs Umuleri
2. Agila vs Ngbo (Ebonyi and Ado LGA)

SOUTH-SOUTH NIGERIA

1. Urhobo vs Itsekiri
2. Communal and Oil induced conflicts in the Niger-Delta
3. Ogoni vs Federal government of Nigeria over Oil spillage. This has increased in scope and intensity.

NORTH-WEST NIGERIA

1. Religious crises triggered by Metatsaine in Kano, katsina, Kaduna,Bauchi, Adamawa and Zaria.
2. Zango-Kataf vs Hausa community in Jama'a LGA Kaduna state
3. Lere vs Saminaka
4. COE Kafanchan religious crisis 1987.

NORTH-EAST NIGERIA

1. Islamic extremism-(Boko haram insurgents, ISIS,AQIM
2. Kuteb vs Jukun
3. Chamba vs Kuteb
4. Mambilla vs Bansa, Kamba, and Fulani(Mambilla plateau)

These perennial conflicts manifest because of the challenge of how to cope with the problem of the ethnic diversities, and more saliently how to accommodate the differences in the true spirit of unity in diversity. **What is diversity?**

Diversity denotes having a range of people with racial and ethnic differences, socio-economic and cultural background with varying lifestyles, experience and interest.

INDIGENE/SETTLER DICHOTOMY

The federal character Principle was established to protect disadvantaged groups via creation of States and LGA's. Recently, the principle has become more problematic than what it purports to solve. Theseperennial conflicts in the zones stimulate the debate on Citizenship crisis in the

country. In contemporary times, the social discourse raises contestable issues on the indigeneity question. The controversy raises several issues because of ambiguous constitutional clauses on who should be recognized as a Citizen and a settler.

As an instance, the indigeneity question in the 1979 constitution has tended to legitimize discriminatory practices against Nigerians, upsetting ethnic and linguistic backgrounds especially those who reside within states that is not their own. For purpose of clarity, the following questions are germane; **who is an indigene in Nigeria? Why are several ethnic groups classified as settlers and non-indigenes, visitors, migrants, what should be the right of a Nigeria Citizen?**

Should the rights of a Nigeria citizen be enjoyed in selected locations?

The 1979 constitution provides that Indigene ship of a state is conferred on a person whose parents or grand parents were members of the community indigenous to a particular state.

Recently, there are claims and counter claims by some groups that most ethnic nationalities are settlers, visitors and non-indigenes where they live and have no ownership rights to the land they occupy. These contestations have generated bloody dramatic scenes in the past. Similar claims and counter claims have pitched ethnic nationalities against each other resulting to wanton destruction of lives and property. (Agaba)

The constitutional provision on indigeneity question has implications on the survival of Nigeria in a number of ways.

1. Tension exists between the former provision in the constitution on citizenship and fundamental rights on the one hand, and the practical application of these rights on the other because of ambiguous clauses such as indigene, natives and settlers.
2. This category tends to undermine the essence of Nigeria citizenship in the sense that one is not really a citizen of Nigeria but only a citizen of a particular state to which his parents are indigenous

DISCRIMINATION

Another problem that exists in the co-existence of ethnic groups in Nigeria is **discrimination**. This manifests in different forms especially during admission and employment of prospective applicants. It even becoming quite evident in churches. The Nigeria society experiences discrimination against ethnic groups living in other parts of Nigeria concerning their rights to live and land they occupy. In particular, several ethnic groups suffer derision nomenclature.

As an instance

1. Igbo refer to Yoruba as AFE
2. Fulani refer to Tiv as MUNCHI
3. Hausa refer to Igbo as Inyamiri
4. Igbo refer to Hausa as NDIAGWU
5. Yoruba refer to Hausa as Gambari

These issues do not only raise questions on the essence of being a Nigerian but entrenches divisive tendencies among ethnic groups. many citizens suffer discrimination and are denied certain rights where they live because the communities consider such citizens as settlers, visitors and non-indigenes.

WHAT IS THE POSITION OF THE CONSTITUTION

1. Section 42 of the 1999 constitution abhors discrimination to Nigerians by virtue of their ethnic affiliation, sex and creed

2. Chapter iv states that:

Nigerians from all ethnic backgrounds and political persuasion or divide must enjoy boundless access to basic rights and freedom wherever they live.

i) We must avoid problems that create crisis in our communities in order to stimulate socio-economic development.

ii) The economy of a nation dwindles where crisis persist.

iii) The Business community cannot infuse their capital in conflict zones

iv) Citizenship crisis portends negatively for sustainable economic growth

The Tiv-Jukun inquest(investigation into a fact of the situation particularly one that bring undesired outcome) gives an insight on indigeneity question in most parts of Nigeria. It indicates that the discrimination some groups suffer is selective and deliberate. This stems from the following facts:

1. There are Igbos in Delta who are less indigenous despite their large numbers in other states in South-East.
2. There is nothing wrong with Kanuri presence in Borno and Nasarawa states,
3. The Jukun are found in Benue, Taraba and Nasarawa states. Yet no Nigeria refer to them as settlers In spite of their small population.
4. What is wrong and unacceptable with Tiv presence in Nasarawa, Benue and Taraba states.
5. What is wrong with Nri presence in Bokkos and Mangu LGA'S of plateau state.

We can curtail further blood letting and eminent blood bath if we respect the rights of other Nigerians irrespective of ethnic group. We can take a cue from USA that accommodates their diversity by harnessing the best talents for sustainable growth.

EFFECTS OF INDIGENE/SETTLER DICHOTOMY

1. The perennial conflicts over land contestations, ethno-religious conflicts and ecological conflicts create problems that have rippling effects on national security and economic development.
2. The conflicts create problems that are detrimental to social integration
3. Conflicts portends negatively to sustainable economic growth
4. Conflicts result to loss of lives and economic investments.

RECOMMENDATIONS

1. Nigerians should learn to promote peaceful co-existence between the various groups
2. Nigeria should learn to manage their diversity where the best talents are harnessed based on potentials and capabilities if we must promote efficiency and productivity in service.

Government should encourage negotiation and dialogue between groups in conflict.
3. All Nigerians irrespective of ethnic affiliation and creed must enjoy their rights where
4. ever they chose to live without molestation.
5. Government should return to the political bureau report which recommend the adoption of full residency rights for Nigerians where ever they reside provided such citizens are made to fulfill minimum residency right of 10 years.